Quebec's new separatist government wants a bigger role in EU ties

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Quebec's new separatist government wants a bigger role in EU ties

By Jacob Parry · Oct 26, 2026, 6:55 PM · View in your browser

BRUSSELS — Quebec's new separatist government is treating this week's EU-Canada summit in Montreal as the start of a wider diplomatic push to get the province in the room whenever Ottawa and Brussels strike deals that concern its powers.

The separatist Parti Québécois returned to power this month at the head of a minority government in the province, promising to assert greater control over Quebec's affairs and eventually hold another referendum on independence.

"Quebec has to be at the table, and Canada understands that very well," Hélène Drainville, the province's delegate general to the Benelux and the EU institutions, told POLITICO in an interview in Brussels.

Prime Minister Mark Carney hosts Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and European Council President António Costa on Thursday and Friday for a summit the two sides have billed as a step change in relations , driven by Donald Trump's tariffs and a shared need for new partners. Von der Leyen has even proposed to make Canada an "associate member" of the EU — an offer that goes too far for some of the bloc's member countries.

Early drafts of a joint summit declaration include a digital trade deal, a pact to let the European Investment Bank finance Canadian critical minerals projects, and a consignment of Canadian water bombers for Europe's emergency services.

While Canada is responsible for negotiating the text, much of it lands in areas where its 10 provinces have extensive powers, such as natural resources, education and health. Quebec is the second-largest province by population after Ontario and has a territory more than twice the size of France — with which three-quarters of its people share French as their mother tongue.

"Canada negotiates the umbrella agreement, and where we come in is when what's negotiated touches our areas of jurisdiction," said Drainville, who has been in post for a year. Natural resources are a provincial matter, she added, noting that Quebec has deposits of 22 of the 34 minerals on the EU's critical list.

The province is already talking to the European Investment Bank and DG GROW, the European Commission's industry department, about the bank's entry into Canada, she noted.

Asked whether Quebec's interests line up with those of Ottawa, Drainville said federal and provincial officials have already set up joint working groups to implement the summit's outcomes. "Right now, all

the signals are green," she said.

New arrival

The cooperation comes at an unusual moment. Quebec's new premier, Paul St-Pierre Plamondon, won power on Oct. 5 while promising a third referendum on sovereignty, though not as long as Trump is in the White House. His cabinet includes the new position of minister for "accession to independence."

However, support for independence in the province is the lowest it has been for three decades (around 29% in a poll from earlier this year) — hardly a popular mandate for the project.

The Parti Québécois has nevertheless pledged to double Quebec's 34 offices abroad. A party blueprint published last year would raise the number of countries with a Quebec office from 19 to 38 and, if the referendum delivers a "yes" to sovereignty, would turn those delegations into embassies and consulates.

"Quebec is going to start to exist and shine everywhere in the world," St-Pierre Plamondon said last year, describing the representative network as a prerequisite for independence .

Drainville said the new government, which has been in office for three weeks, has not yet set its line on Europe.

"Our political leaders haven't taken a position yet, which is normal," she said. "But if they decide to double [the network], it's because they believe in this partnership." As for the associate-member label, she declined to engage: "We're not really into semantics. That's Canada."

What Quebec does want from the EU, she said, is "win-win partnerships," noting that the province and Ottawa complement each other and are stronger together when it comes to relations with Europe.

It hasn't always been so amicable.

Quebec's diplomatic ambitions date back to the 1960s, when the provincial government asserted the right to pursue international relations in areas under its constitutional jurisdiction.

Its international aspirations became politically contentious when French President Charles de Gaulle publicly embraced Quebec's independence movement in 1967 — ending a speech in Montreal by proclaiming: Vive le Québec libre! ("Long live free Quebec!")

The Brussels office opened in 1972 and the province now counts 10 posts in Europe, which Drainville called the most of any Canadian province.

Quebec never consented to the constitutional changes Canada enacted in 1982, and its 1995 independence referendum failed by the narrowest of margins (49.4% to 50.6%). A decade ago, Quebec lobbied Europe for a seat at the table in negotiations on the CETA EU-Canada trade deal.

The provinces hold extensive powers over natural resources, education and health, and Quebec selects most of its own economic immigrants, which gives it more to bargain with than most European regions that keep offices in Brussels.

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